



WHEN SREEJESH RETIRED POST-PARIS, MANY TIPPED KRISHAN PATHAK AS SUCCESSOR, BUT SURAJ KARKERA SEIZED THE CHANCE, SHINING IN THE 2024-25 FIH PRO LEAGUE

former India goalkeeper Dipika Murthy.

But Karkera's identity extends beyond sport. A Naib Subedar with the Bombay Sappers, he carries as much pride in protecting the nation as in defending the goal. Military life sharpened his discipline and outlook.

His inspirations come from military biographies. A chance reading of 1971 war hero (Retd) Major General Ian Cardozo's memoir left a deep impression, prompting him to seek out the veteran in person. "I mostly read military biographies. I try to understand how they coped with pressure situations. I'm also very inspired by the tales of

Field Marshal William Slim."

The time is now

Since his senior debut in 2017 against Belgium, Karkera has made just 39 appearances in seven years. Yet, he made those count, including a 'goalkeeper of the tournament' award at the 2021 Asian Champions Trophy.

Now, with experience and a fresh opportunity, he has become indispensable, featuring in every match since India's bronze medal playoff at the Paris Games. With the 2026 World Cup, Asian Games, and the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics on the horizon, Karkera is determined to make up for lost time.

Rapid-fire



If you weren't a hockey player, what would you be?

I'm in the Army, so a soldier.

Last movie you watched?

The Accountant.

One rule change you want in Hockey?

Have a particular rule about the aerial balls.

If you could get a superpower for a day, what would it be? And what would you do with it?

I would like to watch the Olympic final and play in that.

What is your favourite cheat meal?

Donne Biryani.

Who is your favourite music artist, and which song from them do you love the most?

Piyush Mishra. Aarambh (song title)

Get an outright win in regulation time or a win through a penalty shootout?

Shootout.

If you were stuck on an island, which teammate do you think has the best survival skills to get you out?

Nilakanta Sharma because he's a good cook.

World ends tomorrow, what are you doing today?

Call my family members.

Who's the GOAT of hockey?

Dhanraj Pillay. He's the one who has put Indian hockey on the map.

Best player you have played with or against?

Tobias Hauke of Germany.